

Mian Liu

HEC Paris
Office W2-22 Department of Finance
1 Rue de la Libération
78350 Jouy-en-Josas France

Citizenship: Chinese
Website: <https://mianliu027.github.io/>
Email: mian.liu@hec.edu
Phone: +33 (0)7 65 24 82 34

Education

Ph.D. in Finance, HEC Paris, 2021–2027 (expected)

MRes. in Management, HEC Paris, 2023

MSc. in Finance and Economics (with Distinction), London School of Economics, 2020–2021

BSc. in Statistics, Shanghai University of Finance and Economics, 2016–2020

Research Fields

Corporate Finance, Credit Markets, Macro-Finance

Job Market Paper

Agency Conflicts and Financial Covenants: Theory and Estimates of Control Rights

Abstract: This paper studies how agency conflicts shape the design and enforcement of financial covenants in private debt markets. Using a panel of U.S. syndicated loans from 1996 to 2020, I document a substantial evolution in covenant use and enforcement: the annual incidence of covenant violations declines from 20 percent to below 5 percent over two decades, while the creditor intervention rate following a violation rises from 40 percent to over 70 percent. Importantly, this change is accompanied by a shift in the channels of creditor control rights: while covenant violations continue to constrain investment, their effects on operating income and managerial discipline weaken considerably. To quantify these forces, I develop a micro-founded optimal contracting model in which covenant responds to managerial moral hazard, performance signals, and noncontractible interim actions. By allocating contingent control rights, financial covenants mitigate the lack of cash-flow pledgeability and facilitate financing. I structurally estimate the model using the Simulated Method of Moments, targeting causally identified moments from the reduced-form literature. The estimates show a substantial decrease in both the performance benefits and the managerial costs of creditor intervention. Private-equity sponsorship explains roughly one quarter of this shift, pointing to a broader evolution in the nature of creditor governance.

FIRS-JFI 2026 Best Student Paper Award

Working Papers

The Loan Renegotiation Channel of Quantitative Easing (with Lin Xie)

Endogenously Imperfect Risk Sharing and Financial Amplification

Awards and Fellowships

EFA Doctoral Tutorial Trave Grant, 2026

FIRS-JFI Best Student Paper Award, 2026

École Universitaire de Recherche (EUR) Research Grant, IP Paris, 2025, 2026

Macro Finance Research Program Travel Grant, 2024

HEC Foundation Doctoral Scholarship, HEC Paris, 2021-2026

Outstanding Graduate, Shanghai University of Finance and Economics, 2020

Seminars and Conferences

2026: 10th HEC Paris Finance PhD Workshop, EFA-Doctoral Tutorial, FIRS, HEC Paris

2025 and Prior: HEC Paris, Macro Finance Research Program (MFR) - Poster

Professional service

HEC Paris: 8th HEC Paris Finance PhD Workshop co-organizer (2024)

Teaching

At HEC Paris

Financial Economics (Master), Course Instructor, Fall 2023

Financial Economics (Master), Tutorial Instructor, Fall 2022

Technical Skills

Programming: Julia, MATLAB, R, CUDA/GPU computing, L^AT_EX

Languages: Chinese, English, French (intermediate)

References

Johan Hombert (Advisor)

HEC Paris

hombert@hec.fr

Olivier Darmouni

HEC Paris

darmouni@hec.fr

Quirin Fleckenstein

HEC Paris

fleckenstein@hec.fr

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